

BOOK REVIEWS

T.C. Winebrenner, Editor

Kraus, Sidney. *Televised Presidential Debates and Public Policy* 2nd Edition. Mahwah, NJ: Lawrence Erlbaum, 2000. \$34.50 trade paper. ISBN 0-8058-1603-8. 323 pages.

In the later half of the twentieth century there have been eight presidential elections where the major party candidates engaged in televised joint appearances commonly labeled as “debates.” Although many in the academic debate community believe that labeling these rhetorical events “debates” is a misnomer, the importance of these events is generally accepted. Historians, political scientists, rhetoricians, a range of social scientists, broadcasters, media pundits, sponsors, and debate participants have examined televised presidential debates in a wide variety of critical formats. In this text, Sidney Kraus attempts to bring synergy to a wide range of sources in order to provide a “political history” of the debates. He has fashioned a straightforward book that says what it intends to do and explains the method. The reader is encouraged not only to read the preface to this second edition, but also the included preface to the first edition, and the addendum on his research method. Skipping these preliminaries and moving directly to the first chapter, as most students may be tempted to do, deprives the reader of a sense of the experiential nature of this text. Sidney Kraus is proud of his credentials as a participant observer in the 1976, 1980, 1984, 1988, 1992, and 1996 debates. In the addendum, he explains the press pool credentials he held for the debates and discusses the validity of research that draws from “occupying professional roles and performing real-time tasks in communication events while observing their characteristics, behaviors of the participants, and the environment in which they occur.” The text conveys a vital sense of keen observation of both rhetorical history and political culture, leading to a discussion of implications for public policy. Being a participant observer does not necessarily impair Kraus’s objectivity, but his extensive experience does produce values and predispositions that are important for the reader to understand as underlying assumptions for the text:

- Presidential debates further democratic goals.
- They serve the majority of the electorate better than any other single campaign communication device that attempts to present both the candidates’ personalities and their positions on issues.

- Future televised presidential debates will reach the largest single electoral audience (as they have in the past).
- These debates, and the attention given to them by the electorate, have the potential to bring about changes that improve the presidential selection process and use of television in elections.
- Televised presidential debates should be mandated for all candidates who accept federal campaign funds (p. 6).

This volume is applicable to the interests of a range of students. It provides ample insight into recent presidential election history. For the political science buff, it employs a public policy focus, describes the change in political parties since debates began, and examines how the power structure in campaigns has evolved. Inherent throughout the book is a consideration of the impact of television both on campaigns and the public's view of the Presidency. For the student of media effects, the nature of assessment and the difficulty of designing research to judge media effects is clearly examined. Various research methodologies, as they have been applied to the debates, are examined. Participant observation, as a method, is validated by this work. Kraus' meticulous attention to detailed reportage of his observation is apparent throughout. For example, the complexity of staging a presidential debate is clarified in a twelve page "production diary" for the 1996 San Diego debate. It details the technical aspects of staging that unique "town hall" event.

This second edition of *Televised Presidential Debates and Public Policy* is a greatly expanded revision of the 1988 first edition. This is understandable since Kraus has fashioned a longitudinal history of the presidential debates from 1960 to 1996. Note that it was published before the 2000 election. The first edition covered just the 1960, 1976, 1980 and 1984 debates. With the inclusion of three more election debate cycles, the second edition is a cohesive chronicle of the debate process and production, media coverage, citizen expectations, and reactions. Perhaps Kraus should have included the descriptor "general election" because that is the focus. Primary debates are not considered.

The very brief introductory chapter indicates the significance of debate assessments to persuade the public and policy makers of the debates' continuing importance. It includes an annotated bibliography of 23 major reviews and assessments of the first six debates. The second chapter provides an overview of the relationship of television and presidential elections. Because of the nature of "permanent campaign" and the role of political advisors, labeled as "image manipulators," the role of candidates' debate coach is considered, albeit

too briefly. Memorable phrasing is a primary goal illustrated with Ronald Reagan's unforgettable 1980 phrase "there you go again." Kraus doesn't mention political coaches names, but this reviewer knows the former intercollegiate debate coach who coached Reagan in 1980 and fashioned that response for use at a strategic moment. Overall this section posits the thesis that television plays the key role in establishing the presidential candidate's image. Although written before the popularity of the television drama *West Wing*, Kraus does recognize the symbiotic relationship of television and presidential politics: "Actors and candidates are often so at ease in their execution of their roles, and audiences are so accustomed to accepting the 'reality' of their performances, that the television entertainment environment and the television political campaign environment have become virtually identical" (p. 23).

Academic debate practitioners and those who teach political rhetoric will appreciate that the third chapter on debate formats is the longest in the text. It covers 116 pages, a third of the book, with an historical record of the difficulties in arriving at a format for each of the debates. This reviewer has been a candidate's representative and coach, and also been a neutral producer and moderator of televised debates. It seems that the most difficult phase of debate preparation is getting a format arrangement agreed upon by both parties. From an academic debate perspective, the most frustrating feature of this process is the unwillingness of candidates' representatives to agree to the use of rebuttals and focused in-depth discussion of significant issues where unscripted clash can occur. The reasons why this occurs are well explained in chapter 3. A useful feature is the detailed "Memorandum of Understanding" that Vice President Bush and Governor Dukakis agreed to in 1988 (p. 70-75). The struggle for control of debate sponsorship is intriguing and there is a detailed explanation of how the neutral League of Women Voters lost control of debate sponsorship. The integration of various sections of the text is apparent as the discussion of the controversy causes the reader to want to jump ahead to chapter 6 on debate politics and public policy. Anyone who has worked with political campaigns, coached candidates, moderated debates, or written debate analyses realizes that Kraus is on target with his concluding remarks that "candidates control the negotiations process" (p. 133). Strategically, debate negotiators wish to set the features of the debate in their candidates' favor because:

- Controlling the negotiations increases favorable formats for candidate.
- Favorable formats increase the likelihood of achieving favorable exposure for candidate.

- Favorable exposure increases the likelihood of winning the debate.
- Winning the debate increases the probability of winning the election (p. 134).

Chapter 4, "Debate Coverage: Who's Winning," explains the American media propensity to report a political debate as though it were a horse race or a prize fight. The reporter's need to visualize the debate for those who didn't listen carefully and the public's seeming need to be told by pundits who won, creates an atmosphere where the rhetoric of the spin doctors plays a crucial role in determining the ultimate winner. Although Kraus recognizes our cultural proclivity to view debates in a dichotomous win-lose frame, and includes discussion of our love of scholastic athletics, it is anomalous that he fails to mention competitive scholastic or intercollegiate forensics. Readers from the forensics community will be disappointed to realize that nowhere in the text is there an illustration from, or even clear reference to, the rich theory and practice of academic argumentation and debate that might shed insight on which candidate actually did debate most effectively.

The fifth chapter deals with the effects of the debates, and the subtitle states the author's theme, "Voter's Win." It may not be clear which candidate "won," but the comparison voters can make between the candidates in the debate situation is a major positive factor for the public. But what are the voters comparing? Discussion of the impact of debates follows a range of media effects research with a substantial focus on polling. An in-depth consideration of the types of questions that pollsters have asked in the major post debate opinion polls is interesting. How questions are phrased and the focus of the questions thus frames the later impression of the poll's winner. "The paucity of issues questions asked since 1960 is disturbing. It is disturbing because usually one of the erudite justifications for presidential debates is *democratic theory*, especially the view that an informed electorate will rationally choose the 'best' representatives" (p. 197). The chapter builds a case that the focus of polling and pundits' is on image and strategy rather than on substance. An exceedingly brief section headed "Evaluating Debaters" depends largely on evaluation characteristics employed by columnist David Broder and a discussion of the difficulty candidate debaters have in expressing issues in the prevailing formats. Unfortunately there is no mention of the effort debate coaches have made to evaluate presidential debates employing academic debate criteria. The Associated Press has consistently reported on the reactions of a panel of intercollegiate debate coaches. The CPD and University of Kansas based "Debate Watch" research program that began in 1996 had grown significantly by the 2000 election, and if Kraus had considered the 2000 debates this program would have

merited attention in this section. At the conclusion of this discussion there is a sense that voters learn from the debates, but the question is open: Can the debates activate an electorate with flagging interest in presidential politics?

The final chapter, entitled "Debate Policy: Every Four Years by Mandate," defines the thesis that voters want televised presidential debates because they find something useful in them. Perhaps the value is a token sense of participation in the campaign process that most likely confirms the listener's support, or for a few it may decide or alter their support. Should presidential debates be mandated or institutionalized? Six major policy group studies, conducted between 1976 and 1993, have weighed in on this question and the chapter reports the range of considerations. Four "problem areas" provide the focus of the rest of the chapter: "sponsors, candidate control versus the public interest, format, and public participation." Kraus concludes with his recommendation on how corporate advertising, the use of notes and audiovisuals, and legal and political issues should be handled. The key issue is "mandatory participation" and Kraus has a clear position: the acceptance of federal campaign funds binds the candidate to the commitment to debate. Campaign funds are the *quid pro quo*, the "contract between the candidate and the electorate."

This is a research-based text and it includes a comprehensive bibliography of a range of inquiries. Appropriately the conclusion of the final chapter indicates concerns and ten research questions that warrant exploration to increase knowledge of the effects of various forms of televised presidential debates.

This volume is fascinating because it not only provides rich historical detail on the presidential debates, but it also reports on 20th century media produced mythology. For example, many contemporary references to the Lincoln-Douglas debates neglect the realities of the media and the audience for that 1858 Illinois senatorial campaign. Kraus also debunks the commonly repeated myth that in the 1960 debates Nixon won over the radio audience, but Kennedy won over the TV audience because his comparatively calm demeanor was magnified by the power of the televised image. However on this example, as in many others in the text, Kraus insufficiently examines the linguistic elements of language choice, syntax, and focus of the message that could also be crucial causal factors for audience reaction.

Overall, Kraus coalesces available research with his observations in a unique text that may be employed in the study of political communication, argumentation, persuasion and media effects. Rhetoric and political science intersect in this text. The rhetorician will be

impressed with the descriptions of how power is manipulated in the process of negotiating for, planning, staging, and managing media coverage of elections debates. The political scientist should find that elements of rhetorical analysis are useful in evaluating the past effects of debates and understanding the techniques that campaign operatives prefer in contemporary debates. Anyone interested in political debates should be stimulated to examine questions that are raised by past presidential debate practice.

Don R. Swanson
Monmouth University

Benoit, William L., Blaney, Joseph R., & Pier, P. M. *Campaign '96: A Functional Analysis of Acclaiming, Attacking, and Defending*. Westport, CT: Praeger, 1998. \$62.95 hardcover. ISBN: 0-275-96361-6. 264 pages.

This entry in the Praeger Series in Political Communication attempts to establish “a functional theory of political campaign communication, arguing that such discourse can be understood as acclaiming, attacking, and defending on topics of policy and character” (p. xvii). While I will ultimately claim that the authors’ case requires further refinement to constitute a workable theory, the book provides substantial exposition of problems with current political campaign discourse research and points scholars in potentially productive directions for solutions to these problems. Despite some shortcomings, the book is sufficiently strong to be of interest to political communication and argumentation scholars in search of a supplementary or reserve textbook for classes emphasizing an empirical approach to campaign discourse analysis using a case study recent enough to be familiar to a broad age range of students. Debate scholars interested in political communication may also find the book an interesting analysis of the use of real-world argumentation that closely follows academic debate notions of argument construction, attack, and defense.

Noting that politics necessarily requires a choice between candidates, the authors assert a functional approach to categorizing campaign discourse into one of three categories: *acclaiming*, or self-praise; *attacking*, or criticism of one’s opponent; and *defending*, or response to criticism from opponents (p. xi). Further, the authors separate messages into those speaking to *policies* and those speaking to *character*. Benoit, et al., claim superiority

Copyright of Contemporary Argumentation & Debate is the property of Cross Examination Debate Association and its content may not be copied or emailed to multiple sites or posted to a listserv without the copyright holder's express written permission. However, users may print, download, or email articles for individual use.